

Easton Steffen

I am a member of the IT team responsible for making sure ticket scanners and concessions registers work. My team works hard leading up to and during every game to ensure the best experience for our fans. This is not an easy task, based on how many people will be there and how the venue is built. My main role is to ensure that wifi reaches all the devices it needs to. Another aspect is making sure that only the ticket scanner and registers are on that wifi network.

Take the Dome, for example. This is one of the hardest venues to get wifi working correctly in. The reason is that the Dome is mostly concrete, which blocks wifi signal from getting through. Another issue with the construction of the Dome is that it was not built with wifi in mind. Therefore, there are not many places to place routers so they cover hot spots. These issues are only the start. Due to the construction, we have to be very intentional about where routers are placed for ticket scanners. We also need to make sure that those with the ticket scanners don't wander too far from where they are supposed to be. We also have to pick routers that will work. Depending on how large we need the reach of wifi to be, the price of that route goes up. The budget we have for getting routes is also a huge limiting factor. We have to be smart with what we do.

In regard to making sure the devices work, my team works all gameday, checking on the scanners and registers, and responding to calls when they don't work. I typically respond to 1-2 calls a game to check on the ticket scanner. These are the most susceptible to issues because they are moving around where the registers are stationary and don't move. They also have the advantage of being able to have routes

close by due to how concession stands are built. There are so many places you can hide a router. The scanners can also have software issues. These issues can be a huge issue. It can slow down the rate at which people enter the stadium. This is not fun for the fans or staff. For the fans, because they want to get in. And for the staff, because it means unhappy fans, which can lead to issues. It also means that the staff has to do more than they already have to do. You really don't want to stretch your staff out too far.

One big issue we deal with ahead of time is making sure our networks are secure. We do not want other devices on the same network as the scanners and registers. Having too many devices on the network can cause a lot of downtime, thus slowing down how fast staff are able to use their devices. Again, not fun for anyone. We also want to keep unauthorized devices off for security reasons. We don't want someone hacking into our registers.

These are just some of the issues IT and my team have to deal with on game days. Anything can go wrong during game day. We are always ready to respond to any issues the staff might have regarding our network. This is a very complex and constantly changing job. And one that helps sporting events happen in the first place.

Note: This is mostly true in the sense that the IT team has to do a lot of work with routes. I don't really know what they do during game days, but I can infer from what they talked about when they visited my networking class last semester.